

14 The past perfect continuous

English uses the past perfect continuous with the past simple to talk about an activity that was in progress before another action or event happened.

See also:

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14.1 THE PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS

The past simple refers to a specific completed event in the past. The past perfect continuous describes a repeated action or continuing activity that was taking place before that completed event.

PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS

He **had been studying** English for two years before he **went** to London.

PAST SIMPLE



TWO YEARS BEFORE

PAST

NOW

By the time Katie **arrived** home, she **had been driving** for six hours.



SIX HOURS BEFORE

PAST

NOW

HOW TO FORM

The past perfect continuous is formed using "had been" plus a present participle.

SUBJECT

"HAD BEEN"

VERB + "-ING"

REST OF SENTENCE

He

had been

studying

English for two years.

"Had been" doesn't change with the subject.